

Urdu, Step by Step, Root by Root

A gentle, etymology-driven introduction to contemporary Urdu

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Starter edition — eight short chapters, with more being written.

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Preface

This book teaches Urdu one word at a time, and it teaches each word by taking it apart. It assumes no Urdu and no Perso-Arabic script: every section takes one small expression, introduces only the letters, sounds, and grammar that expression needs, connects it to words you may already know, and ends by asking for it back. Urdu reads right to left — but you will be reading real words long before you have met the whole alphabet.

Urdu makes several histories visible at once. Its grammar and much of its everyday vocabulary are Indo-Aryan, closely related to Hindi, while Persian and Arabic have contributed a large literary and formal layer on top. Etymology in this book is a memory aid — never a claim that a borrowed word is any less fully Urdu today.

One honest note about the type. Urdu is traditionally printed in the flowing, descending *Nastaliq* style. This edition sets it in Naskh instead, which is legible and reproduces identically everywhere, while a suitable Nastaliq face is found. The language, the joining behaviour, and the right-to-left order are Urdu; only the style of the letterforms is not, and it seemed better to say so than to let you assume otherwise.

This is a starter edition: eight short chapters, complete in themselves, with more being written.

How to use this book

Every numbered section is one word, or one small phrase, and takes a few minutes — the length of a queue, an errand, or the walk to the bus. Read them in order the first time through: each section stands on the ones before it, and nothing is used before it has been taught. After that the book becomes reference, and you can open it anywhere.

Say the Urdu out loud wherever you can. The prompts under *Your turn* are written to be spoken, and saying a word is most of what makes it

stay. The questions under *Before you move on* carry their own answers in brackets: cover them, answer from memory, then look.

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Chapter 1

Greetings and responses

This chapter builds one miniature exchange in dependency order: greet, thank, answer yes, answer no. Four short expressions establish right-to-left reading, joining, omitted short vowels, long vowels, respectful *jī*, and one Urdu nasal sign.

1.1 سلام (*salām*) — hello through peace

Read only what this expression needs

Urdu runs **right to left**. Read سلام from its right edge: س *s*, ل *l*, ā long ā, م *m*. Letters usually join inside a word. The tall *l* does not connect to the following letter, so the final م begins a new stroke group. No other letters are due yet.

Where the expression came from

Salām is a greeting and the word “peace.” Urdu received it through the Persian-Arabic literary world. Its consonants **s–l–m** belong to a Semitic family concerned with peace, safety, and wholeness. Persian *salām*, Arabic *salām*, and Hebrew *shalom* make the historical family especially visible.

Use it now

Say سلام to begin a friendly exchange. For now the safest reply is the same word: A says سلام; B answers سلام. One useful move is enough.

One-minute checkpoint

Read سلام from right to left. Which letter carries long *ā*? Point to ل, cover the romanization, and say *salām* once.

1.2 شکرِیہ (*shukriyā*) — thank you**Read only what this expression needs**

Urdu normally leaves short vowels unmarked. Read the visible guide: ش *sh*, ک *k*, ر *r*, ی *y/i*, ہ final *h*-shape. The learned whole supplies the short *u* and *i*, while the ending is pronounced long *ā*. First remember one joined word, not every possible letter form.

Where the expression came from

The central consonants **sh–k–r** belong to the Arabic family for gratitude; Arabic *shukran* is a close comparison. Urdu *shukriyā* reflects its long Persian-Arabic lexical history and is an ordinary modern Urdu expression.

Use it now

Build a two-step chain: سلام *salām* — hello; شکرِیہ *shukriyā* — thank you. Keep the second word in three light beats: *shuk-ri-yā*.

One-minute checkpoint

Which new letter begins شکرِیہ? Point to ش, say *sh*, then produce *salām* — *shukriyā* without looking.

1.3 جی ہاں (*jī hā*) — yes, respectfully**Read only what this expression needs**

This answer has two small words. In جی, ج gives *j* and ی stretches the vowel to *ī*. In ہاں, the final ہ is **nūn ghunna**: it nasalizes long *ā* rather than adding a strong English *n*. Let a little air pass through the nose.

Use it now

ہاں means “yes.” Adding جی makes the response attentive and respectful; جی can also answer by itself. Learn the safely courteous whole first: جی ہاں *jī hā*.

One-minute checkpoint

Which final sign nasalizes the vowel? Point to ں. Then answer politely: جی ہاں.

1.4 نہیں (*nahī*) — no, and later not**Read only what this expression needs**

Reuse ہ, ی, and nasal ں; add ن *n* at the right edge. The result is نہیں *nahī*. Stretch *ī* slightly and nasalize it; do not add a separate forceful *n* at the end.

Where the expression came from

Unlike the Persian-Arabic vocabulary that opened the chapter, *nahī* belongs to Urdu’s inherited Indo-Aryan core. Hindi *nahī* is the same spoken word written in a different script. The shared form previews close grammatical kinship without making Hindi script a prerequisite.

Use it now

As a complete answer, نہیں means “no.” Inside a later sentence it will also mean “not,” but that second job can wait. Contrast only: جی ہاں — yes; نہیں — no.

One-minute checkpoint

Without looking back, produce the chain hello, thank you, yes, no. Then read سلام, شکریہ, جی ہاں, نہیں in the same order.

Chapter 2

Give your name

The first chapter supplied social moves. This one adds one sentence and one word-order fact: Urdu places the present copula at the end.

2.1 میرا نام ... ہے — my name is ...

Read the Urdu phrase from right to left while keeping its spoken word order:

میرا نام سارا ہے۔
merā nām Sārā hai — My name is Sara.

Read only what this expression needs

Nearly every shape is recycled. میرا begins with م from سلام, then reuses ی, ر, and ا. نام reuses ن, ا, and م. In final ہے, the only new form is ے, called *barī ye*; here the whole word is pronounced *hai*. Learn that diphthong with the word.

Use it now

Assemble four slots:

1. میرا *merā* — my;
2. نام *nām* — name;
3. your name;
4. ہے *hai* — is.

The reusable pattern is **my** + **name** + **NAME** + **is**. Urdu places *hai* at the end. Replace Sara with your name and keep every other slot.

Where the expression came from

Nām continues an old Indo-Aryan form related to Sanskrit *nāman* and, much farther back, English *name*. The possessive *merā* and copula *hai* also belong to Urdu’s inherited grammar. The sentence therefore follows the Indo-Aryan layer that Urdu shares closely with Hindi, even though Urdu writes it in the Perso-Arabic script.

One-minute checkpoint

Where does “is” go? At the end. Point to **ۛ**, then replace Sara with your own name and say the full four-slot sentence once.

What is deliberately deferred

Urdu possessives agree with the noun they describe; *merā* has this form because *nām* is grammatically masculine, not because of the speaker’s gender. That rule, other possessive forms, and the rest of the copula paradigm belong to later lessons. The fixed introduction works for every speaker now.

Chapter 3

Ask and Answer Names

By the end of this chapter: I can ask someone’s name with respectful āp, answer with my own, and close the introduction politely.

A six-line first meeting: greet, ask āp k̄ nām kyā hai?, answer with your own name, and close with āp se mil kar khushī hū.

3.1 آپ / تم / تو — three relationships inside “you”

Say **merā nām ... hai** with your own name. To ask the other person’s name, begin with the respectful form.

You’ll want to know first — three forms

Urdu	read	use
آپ	āp	respectful: a new adult, elder, or anyone you wish to honor
تم	tum	familiar: friends and peers
تو	tū	intimate, or downward; unsafe as a beginner default

آپ begins with Ā, an alif carrying the long ā mark, then پ p. تم and تو share t. In تو, و carries long ū.

Grammar Lens: choose the relationship first

English flattened these choices into one *you*. Urdu keeps three. Use **āp** in a first meeting. Move to **tum** when the relationship supports familiarity. Save **tū** for relationships where you already know it is welcome; used badly, it can sound belittling.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Tum/tū belong to the old Indo-European familiar-“you” family: Sanskrit *tvam*, English **thou**, and Latin *tū* are relatives. **Āp** followed another route: a word connected with “self/oneself” became honorific address.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- a new adult — **āp**
- a friend — **tum**
- the old family — **tum, tvam, thou**

Before you move on

Which form is safest when unsure? (**Āp**.) Which familiar forms share history with English *thou*? (**Tum/tū**.)

Source: *Basic Urdu*: Cultural Notes.

3.2 کیا — what

Which “you” opens a respectful first meeting? (آپ, *āp*.) Now add the question word.

You’ll want to know first — کیا

کیا — *kyā* — **what**

Read right to left: ک *k*, ی supplying the *y* glide here, then ا long *ā*. The same ی carried long *ī* in جی and نہیں. Its job depends on the word; here the learned shape is *kyā*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Urdu **kyā** and Hindi **kyā** are the same inherited Indo-Aryan word in different scripts. Their history reaches Sanskrit *kim* and the old Indo-European *k/kw-* question family behind English **wh-** words such as *what*, *who*, and *which*. The bridge helps memory; Urdu کیا remains the form you must read here.

Your turn

- Say it: **kyā** — what
- Read it: کیا as **k** + **yā**
- Say it: the family — **kyā**, **what**, **who**, **which**

Before you move on

Which letter acts as *y* here but as long *ī* in جی؟ (ی.) What does کیا mean? (**What**.)

3.3 آپ کا نام — ask a name respectfully

Recall **āp** “you,” **kyā** “what,” and the answer **merā nām ... hai**. The question reuses all three.

The exchange

آپ کا نام — *āp kā nām kyā hai?* — **What is your name?**

Build it in spoken order:

you + **kā** + name + what + is?

Āp kā means “your” in this frame. The possessive form agrees with the thing owned: **nām** is masculine singular, so use **kā**. Keep that one pairing; the full *kā/kī/ke* system can wait. As in your answer, **hai** stays at the end.

Script: the question mark

Urdu ends the question with ؟, curved for a right-to-left line. Begin at آپ on the right and reach the punctuation at the far left.

Your turn

- *Say it:* āp k̄ā nām kyā hai?
- *Say it:* ask, then answer — merā nām ... hai
- *Point to:* to ؟ at the end

Before you move on

Ask once without romanization. Where does **hai** remain? (At the end.)

Source: *Basic Urdu: Greetings and Introductions*.

3.4 آپ سے مل کر خوشی ہوئی — pleased to meet you

Ask āp k̄ā nām kyā hai? and answer merā nām ... hai.

This fixed response now closes the meeting.

The exchange

آپ سے مل کر خوشی ہوئی۔ āp se mil kar khushī huī **Pleased to meet you.**

For now, hold three meaning-sized chunks:

- āp se — with you
- mil kar — having met
- khushī huī — happiness happened

That yields the memorable literal picture: “**Having met you, happiness happened.**” The phrase is one social move; later lessons can generalize *se*, *-kar*, and past agreement one at a time.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Khushī “happiness” comes from Persian **khosh/khush** “pleasant, happy.” **Mil** “meet” and **huī** “happened” belong to Urdu’s inherited Indo-Aryan grammar. The sentence therefore joins Urdu’s two major historical layers without becoming any less ordinary Urdu.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- āp se | mil kar | khushī huī in three beats
- the literal picture — “having met you, happiness happened”
- which word came through Persian — **khushī**

Before you move on

Say the response once as a whole. Which chunk means “happiness happened”? (**Khushī huī**.)

Source: *Basic Urdu*: Greetings and Introductions.

3.5 Practice — a complete Urdu name exchange

Recall the four moves without adding anything: greet, ask, answer, acknowledge.

The exchange

A: سلام! — *Salām!* B: سلام! — *Salām!* A: ہے؟ کیا نام کا آپ — *Āp kā nām kyā hai?* B: ہے۔ سارا نام میرا — *Merā nām Sārā hai.* A: شکریہ۔ — *Āp se mil kar khushī huī.* B: شکریہ۔ — *Shukriyā.*

Every line is already known. **Āp** keeps the meeting respectful; **hai** stays at the end of both name sentences; ؟ ends the question at the line’s left.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- both voices, using your own name
- the exchange again without romanization
- only the three name moves — question, answer, response

Before you move on

Run the meeting once from **salām** to **shukriyā**. If a line stalls, review only that micro-lesson.

Chapter 4

How Are You?

By the end of this chapter: I can ask how someone is with respectful āp, choose kaise or kaisī for the person I am addressing, and reply that I am fine, thank you.

The wellbeing exchange run both ways — āp kaise haiñ? and āp kaisī haiñ? — answered with the unchanging main̄ ṭhīk hūñ, shukriyā.

4.1 کیسی / کیسے — “how” follows the addressee

Say **kyā** “what.” Urdu’s next question word begins with the same **k** family, but its ending changes with the person being addressed.

The two words

Urdu	read	use in the respectful question
کیسے	<i>kaise</i>	addressing a man
کیسی	<i>kaisī</i>	addressing a woman

Both begin ک *k* + ی carrying the *ai* sound. At the left edge, کیسے ends in broad ے *e*, while کیسی ends in ی long ī. Read the whole word before isolating the final shape.

Grammar Lens: one agreement contrast

English keeps *how* unchanged. Urdu makes this describing form agree with the person addressed: **kaise** for a man, **kaisī** for a woman. Learn only this pair today—not a table of adjective endings. Respectful āp

itself remains the same for everyone.

Your turn

- *Say it:* addressing a man — **kaise**
- *Say it:* addressing a woman — **kaisī**
- *Point to:* broad final ے versus long-ī ی

Before you move on

Which form addresses a man? (**Kaise.**) A woman? (**Kaisī.**)
Source: *Basic Urdu: Formal Conversation.*

4.2 آپ کیسے ہیں؟ / آپ کیسی ہیں؟ — ask respectfully

Choose respectful **āp**. Then choose **kaise** for a man or **kaisī** for a woman. One final copula completes the question.

The exchange

to a man: آپ کیسے ہیں؟ — *āp kaise haiñ?* to a woman: آپ کیسی ہیں؟
— *āp kaisī haiñ?*

The order is **you + how + are?** Keep *haiñ* final, just as *hai* stayed final in the name question. Respectful **āp** takes this plural-shaped copula even when speaking to one person.

Grammar Lens: respect does not erase agreement

Both lines are respectful. The choice between **kaise** and **kaisī** tracks the person addressed, not greater or lesser politeness. If you do not know how a person wishes to be addressed, listen for their usage or ask rather than guess; the grammar lesson does not replace social judgment.

Your turn

- *Say it:* to a man — **āp kaise haiñ?**
- *Say it:* to a woman — **āp kaisī haiñ?**

- *Keep*: respectful **āp** and final **haiñ** in both

Before you move on

What stays the same in both lines? (**Āp ... haiñ.**) What changes? (**Kaise / kaisī.**)

Sources: *Basic Urdu: Formal Conversation and Personal Pronouns* with “To Be”.

4.3 میں ... ہوں — one frame for “I am ...”

Ask **āp kaise haiñ**? You know the respectful “you are” ending **haiñ**. Your answer needs the first-person pair “I ... am.”

You’ll want to know first — the frame

میں ... ہوں — *main ... hūn* — I am ...

میں *main* means “I.” Final ں marks a nasal ending. ہوں *hūn* means “am” and carries long *ū* with و, followed again by nasal ں. Leave a space for the state word that comes next.

Grammar Lens: the verb closes the frame

Urdu puts the copula at the end:

main + [state] + hūn — I + [state] + am

Learn only this first-person frame. You do not need the full copula chart to answer one wellbeing question. Notice the useful contrast: respectful **āp ... haiñ**, but first-person **main ... hūn**.

Your turn

- *Say it*: **main** — I
- *Say it*: **hūn** — am
- *Frame*: **main ... hūn**, leaving the middle open

Before you move on

Which word opens the answer? (**Maiñ.**) Which copula closes it? (**Hūñ.**)

Source: *Basic Urdu*: Personal Pronouns with “To Be”.

4.4 ٹھیک — “fine,” “well,” and “correct”

Open and close the answer frame: **maiñ ... hūñ**. The middle now gets one high-frequency state word.

You’ll want to know first — the word

ٹھیک — *ṭhīk* — fine, well, correct

The first sound is retroflex and aspirated: curl the tongue slightly back for *ṭ*, then release a puff marked by *ḥ*. A plain English *t* is a useful first approximation while the contrast settles. *ی* carries long *ī* before final *ک*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Urdu ٹھیک and Hindi *ṭhīk* are the same everyday Hindustani word. Their grammar is closely shared; their scripts make different literary histories visible. This Urdu lesson leaves the Hindi side romanized: mixed-language practice may show both scripts only after each form has been learned in its own track.

Your turn

- Say it: **ṭhīk** — fine, well
- Feel: tongue slightly back, then a small puff
- Connect: Urdu ٹھیک ↔ Hindi *ṭhīk*

Before you move on

Where will **ṭhīk** go in the frame **maiñ ... hūñ**? (In the middle.)

Source: *Basic Urdu*: Greetings and Introductions.

4.5 شکر یہ ہوں، ٹھیک میں — “I am fine, thank you”

Fill the frame **main** ... **hūn** with **ṭhīk**, then recall Chapter 1’s **shukriyā**.

The exchange

شکر یہ ہوں، ٹھیک میں *Main ṭhīk hūn, shukriyā. I am fine, thank you.*

No word is new. The step is assembling the words quickly enough to answer a real person.

Grammar Lens: keep the copula final

The core reply is:

I + fine + am → **main ṭhīk hūn**

English places “am” after “I”; Urdu closes the clause with **hūn**. **Shukriyā** comes after the completed answer as the courtesy move you already own.

Your turn

- *Build*: **main + ṭhīk + hūn**
- *Add*: **shukriyā**
- *Say it*: the full reply without translating each word

Before you move on

Which word must close the core answer? (**Hūn**.)

Source: *Basic Urdu: Formal Conversation*.

4.6 Practice — an Urdu wellbeing exchange

Choose the question ending for the person addressed, then retrieve the complete answer before looking below.

The exchange

A to a man: سلام! آپ کیسے ہیں؟ *Salām! Āp kaise haiñ?* A to a woman: سلام! آپ کیسی ہیں؟ *Salām! Āp kaisī haiñ?* B: ٹھیک میں شکریہ۔ ہوں، *Main ṭhīk hūñ, shukriyā.*

The question keeps respectful **āp** and final **haiñ** while **kaise/kaisī** agrees with the addressee. The reply is unchanged for the speaker's gender: **ṭhīk** does not change, and first-person **hūñ** closes the line.

Grammar Lens: separate grammar from guessing

The two question forms are a grammatical contrast, not an instruction to infer someone's identity. In real interaction, follow the person's own language or ask. The stable beginner default is respect: **āp ... haiñ**.

Your turn

- *Say it:* the man-addressed exchange
- *Say it:* the woman-addressed exchange
- *Answer:* **maiñ ṭhīk hūñ, shukriyā** after either question

Before you move on

Run both question variants once. If the choice stalls, review only **kaise/kaisī**; if the answer order stalls, review only **maiñ ... hūñ**.

Chapter 5

Take Leave

By the end of this chapter: I can open a short Urdu conversation, ask how the other person is, and close it with *khudā hāfiz*.

A four-line interaction with a beginning and an end: salām, the well-being check, then khudā hāfiz from both voices.

5.1 خدا — the first half of an Urdu farewell

Run one known wellbeing exchange. Chapter 5 will add only the move that ends it.

You'll want to know first — one word

خدا — *khudā* — God

Read from right to left: خ *kh* + د *d* + ا long *ā*. The short *u* is learned with the word and is normally unwritten. Let **kh** come from farther back than English *h*, but keep the sound relaxed.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Urdu borrowed **khudā** from Persian **khodā**, whose older Middle Persian ancestor *xwadāy* meant “lord.” Learn the Urdu sound and script first; the Persian connection then explains why both tracks will share the phrase’s first historical layer.

Your turn

- Say it: **khudā** — God

- *Read it:* خدا from the right edge
- *Connect:* Urdu **khudā** ← Persian **khodā**

Before you move on

Which final letter carries long **ā**? (l.) Which short vowel must be remembered with the word? (u.)

Sources: *Basic Urdu: Greetings and Introductions*; Wiktionary: خدا.

5.2 حافظ — “guardian” or “protector”

Read خدا and say **khudā**. Keep it separate while one second word is added.

You’ll want to know first — one word

حافظ — *hāfīz* — guardian, protector

Read ح ف ا ظ from right to left. ا carries long **ā**. Final ظ is pronounced **z** in this Urdu word. The short *i* is heard in **hāfīz** but is normally not written as a separate letter.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Arabic **ḥāfīz** is an active participle from **ḥ-f-z**, “guard, preserve.” Urdu receives **hāfīz** through its Persian-Arabic literary layer. Keep “guardian” as the useful meaning; the three-consonant root is a memory hook.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **hāfīz** — guardian, protector
- *Read it:* حافظ
- *Connect:* Arabic **ḥ-f-z** — guard, preserve

Before you move on

What does **hāfīz** contribute to the farewell? (The idea of guarding or protecting.)

Source: American Heritage Dictionary: *hafiz*.

5.3 حافظ خدا — goodbye

Retrieve **khudā** and **hāfiz** separately: “God” + “guardian.”
Now use the two known pieces as one parting move.

The two words — put the known pieces together

حافظ خدا — *khudā hāfiz* — goodbye

Urdu keeps a visible space between the two words. Read خدا first, then حافظ, and preserve that space in the complete spelling حافظ خدا. Say the whole expression smoothly.

Grammar Lens — a whole social move

The protective sense is “God [be] guardian,” but everyday speakers use the formula simply as **goodbye**. No new verb or agreement ending is needed. It is a reliable polite close for the short interaction learned so far.

Script Bridge — shared history, local spacing

Urdu حافظ خدا and Persian خداحافظ share the same historical pieces. Urdu keeps the visible space in this course; Persian normally joins them. Mixed practice may compare the two only now that each local phrase is independently readable.

Your turn

- *Build:* **khudā** + **hāfiz**
- *Read it:* spaced Urdu حافظ خدا
- *Use:* say it when the interaction ends

Before you move on

Where is the local writing contrast? (Urdu shows a space; Persian joins its spelling.)

Source: *Basic Urdu: Greetings and Introductions*.

5.4 Practice — open, check, and close

Retrieve the known expression for the beginning and the new expression for the end. Keep the middle unchanged.

The exchange — the complete interaction

A: سلام! آپ کیسے ہیں؟ *Salām! Āp kaise hain?* B: ہوں، ٹھیک میں *Bon, theek mein*.
 A: خدا حافظ۔ *Khudā hāfiz.* B: شکر ہے۔ *Shukriya.*
 A: خدا حافظ۔ *Khudā hāfiz.* B: خدا حافظ۔ *Khudā hāfiz.*

Every line is already learned. **Salām** opens; **khudā hāfiz** closes. The same farewell works for both speakers, so this practice adds no gender choice, pronoun, or copula form.

Your turn

- *Choose*: meeting begins → **salām**
- *Choose*: interaction ends → **khudā hāfiz**
- *Run through*: both voices once with script, once without romanization

Before you move on

Run the full exchange once. If the final line stalls, return only to the assembled-farewell lesson.

Chapter 6

Five Verbs at the Core

By the end of this chapter: I can name five everyday Urdu verbs by their shared -nā ending, take that ending off to reach the stem, and say what I do in the present with the participle agreeing for gender and the copula agreeing for person.

The fifth verb runs the whole machine at once: strip -nā from all five infinitives, hold the doubled nūn that keeps jānnā apart from jānā, and put the stem into main jāntā/jāntī hūn.

6.1 ہونا — “to be,” and the ending every Urdu verb wears

You can already close an Urdu sentence with ہوں *hūn* — “am.” That small word is a fragment of something larger. Here is the whole verb it was broken off.

You’ll want to know first — one word

ہونا — *honā* — to be

Read from the right edge: ہ *h*, then ں carrying *o*, then ن *n*, then ا long *ā*. Every one of those four shapes has already turned up in a word you have met. There is nothing new to decode here, which is rare, and worth enjoying.

Grammar Lens: the ending that names every verb

honā ends in -ن -*nā*. So does every Urdu verb when you name it. English marks a verb’s plain name by putting a word in front — *to be*, *to go*,

to come. Urdu marks it by putting **-nā** on the end, and never uses a separate word for it.

That ending is also a tool. Strip **-nā** off and what remains is the **stem**, the piece everything else in the verb is built on. **honā** minus **-nā** leaves **ho-**. Learn the ending once, and every new verb hands you its own stem for free.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

honā comes from Sanskrit *bhavati*, “becomes,” built on the root *bhū-*. The middle stage of Indo-Aryan softened that *bh-* to *h-*, so *bhavati* thinned to *hoi* and then to **honā**.

The root is Indo-European: **b^huH-*, “grow, become.” English kept it in **be** and **been**, and — by way of “the place where one dwells” — in **build**, **booth**, and **bower**. Latin held it as *fuī* “I was” and *futūrus*, which English borrowed as **future**. Greek held it as *phúsis* “nature,” which English borrowed as **physics**.

Your turn

- Say it: **honā** — to be
- Strip: **honā** minus **-nā** leaves the stem **ho-**
- Read it: ہونا from the right edge
- Connect: **honā** ← Sanskrit *bhavati* → English **be**

Before you move on

Which ending names an Urdu verb? (**-nā**.) What is left of *honā* once you take that ending off? (**Ho-**.) Which English verb grew from the same ancient root? (**Be**.)

Sources: *Basic Urdu*: Personal Pronouns with “To Be”; Wiktionary: ہونا.

6.2 جانا — “to go,” and two agreements in one sentence

Take the ending off **honā** and say the stem aloud. The next verb gives that same ending a second workout.

You'll want to know first — one word

جانا — *jānā* — to go

From the right edge: ج *j*, then | long *ā*, then ن *n*, then | long *ā*. The ج *j* is the one from جی *jī*. Strip the **-nā** and the stem is **jā-**.

Grammar Lens: the present tense agrees twice

“I go” in Urdu is two words after the pronoun, not one:

میں — *main* — *jātā* *hūn* — I go (man speaking) میں
ہوں — *hūn* — *jātī* *hūn* — I go (woman speaking)

The first word is the stem **jā-** plus **-tā**. It says *going*, and it agrees with the **gender and number** of the person doing it: **-tā** for one man, **-tī** for one woman, **-te** for more than one man or for a respectful singular. The second word is **hūn**, which you already own, and it agrees with **person** — who is speaking.

Two agreements, split across two words, in one short clause. English makes one agreement at most, and usually none. Say both Urdu lines and let the difference sit in the ear rather than on paper.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

jānā continues Sanskrit *yāti*, “goes,” from the root *yā-*, “travel.” The change from *y-* to *j-* is not a quirk of this word: initial *y-* regularly hardened to *j-* on the road from Sanskrit into the middle stage of Indo-Aryan that Urdu descends from. Meet the law once and it decodes other words later.

English gives nothing here. The *yā-* root travelled north and west into Lithuanian and Slavic rather than into Germanic, so this is a word where Sanskrit is the whole hook and English cannot help.

Your turn

- Say it: **jānā** — to go
- Strip: **jānā** minus **-nā** leaves **jā-**
- Say it: **main jātā hūn**, then **main jātī hūn**
- Choose: the ending that fits you — **-tā** or **-tī**

Before you move on

Which word in *main jātā hūn* carries gender? (**Jātā** — the one built on the stem.) Which one carries person? (**Hūn**.) And which Sanskrit verb stands behind *jānā*? (*Yā-*, “travel.”)

Source: Wiktionary: جاتا.

6.3 اُآ — “to come,” which is “go” pointed back at you

Say **jānā**, then its stem **jā-**. The opposite direction is the same verb wearing a prefix.

You’ll want to know first — one word

اُآ — *ānā* — to come

From the right edge: *ā*, then ن *n*, then ا long *ā*. That first shape is *alif madd* — alif wearing a small wave — and it is how Urdu writes a long *ā* at the start of a word. It opens اُ *āp* too. Strip the **-nā** and the stem is **ā-**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ānā continues Sanskrit *āyāti*, and that word is two pieces: *ā-*, “toward,” plus *yā-*, “go.” So the Urdu verb for *coming* is, underneath, the verb for *going* aimed back at the speaker. “Go toward me” is “come.”

You already have the second piece: *yā-* is the same root that hardened into the **j-** of **jānā**. One Sanskrit verb, two Urdu words, and the difference between them is a direction marker.

English does the identical trick with a Latin verb: *venire* “to come” plus a prefix gives **advent**, **convene**, **intervene**, **prevent**, and **revenue**. Urdu welds its prefix on the front and lets the seam disappear; English keeps the seam visible.

Your turn

- Say it: **ānā** — to come
- Pair: **jānā** away, **ānā** toward
- Split: *ā-* “toward” + *yā-* “go”

- Read it: بولنا, starting from *alif madd*

Before you move on

Which two pieces are hiding inside *ānā*? (*Ā*- “toward” and *yā*- “go.”)
 Which Urdu verb shares the second piece? (**Jānā**.) And what does the stem become once **-nā** comes off? (*Ā*-.)
 Source: Wiktionary: بولنا.

6.4 بولنا — “to speak,” and the two layers of Urdu

Three verbs so far, three stems pulled off the same ending. Here is a fourth, and it brings one new letter with it.

You’ll want to know first — one word

بولنا — *bolnā* — **to speak**

From the right edge: ب *b*, then و carrying *o*, then ل *l*, then ن *n*, then ا long *ā*. Strip the **-nā** and the stem is **bol-**.

ب is new, and it is worth one careful second. Its body is a single low scoop with **one dot below**. You have already read پ *p* in آپ *āp*, and پ is that identical scoop with **three dots below**. Same skeleton, different dot count, different consonant. Urdu builds much of its alphabet this way, so counting dots is a real reading skill and not a fussy detail.

Grammar Lens: put it in the frame

The stem takes the same two-agreement frame as before:

میں بولتا ہوں — *main boltā hūn* — **I speak** (man speaking)
 میں بولتی ہوں — *main boltī hūn* — **I speak** (woman speaking)

Nothing new is being learned there. That is the point of a stem: the machine is already built, and each verb just walks into it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

bolnā goes back to Prakrit *bolai*, “speaks” — and then the trail stops. A link onward to Sanskrit *brūte* “speaks” has been proposed, but it is not settled, so treat it as a maybe rather than a fact.

That plainness is the lesson. Urdu’s everyday verbs are inherited Indo-Aryan and often short-rooted like this, while its formal and literary vocabulary was borrowed from Persian and Arabic and tends to be long, elegant, and easy to trace. Beside homely **bolnā** sits Persian-derived گفتگو *guftagū*, “conversation,” from Persian *guftan*, “to speak.” Both are fully Urdu. One is the floor of the house; the other is the ornament on it — and the flowing *nasta‘līq* hand Urdu is traditionally written in belongs to that same Persian inheritance.

Your turn

- Say it: **bolnā** — to speak
- Count: ب one dot below, پ three dots below
- Say it: **maiñ boltā hūñ**, then **maiñ boltī hūñ**
- Sort: **bolnā** inherited, **guftagū** borrowed

Before you move on

How many dots does ب carry, and where? (One, below.) How far back can *bolnā* be traced with confidence? (To Prakrit *bollaï*, and no further.) Which layer of Urdu does *guftagū* belong to? (The Persian one.)

Sources: *Zero Zabar*: The Urdu alphabet; Wiktionary: بولنا.

6.5 جانا — “to know,” a word English has been carrying all along

Run the four verbs you have — *honā*, *jānā*, *ānā*, *bolnā* — and pull the stem off each one. The fifth is the closest of them to English.

You’ll want to know first — one word

جانا — *jānnā* — to know

From the right edge: ج *j*, | long *ā*, then ن, then ن a second time, then | long *ā*. Two separate *nūns*, written out one after the other, and both are

pronounced: hold the *n* long, *jān-nā*, the way English does across the seam of *thin · ness*. Strip the final **-nā** and the stem is **jān-**.

That doubling is what keeps **jānnā** “to know” apart from **jānā** “to go.” One letter, and the whole meaning turns.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

jānnā continues Sanskrit *jānāti*, from the root *jñā-*, “know.” That root is Indo-European **ǵneh₃-*, and English is stuffed with it.

Straight down the Germanic line: **know**, **knowledge**, **can** (once “to know how”), **cunning**, **ken**, and **uncouth** — literally “un-known.” Borrowed from Latin *(g)nōscere*: **notice**, **note**, **notion**, **cognition**, **recognize**, **acquaint**, and **ignore**, which is “not to know.” Borrowed from Greek *gnōsis*: **diagnosis**, **prognosis**, and **agnostic**.

So the Urdu verb is not a stranger. It is a first cousin of the plainest word English has for the same idea, and every one of those borrowings is another place to hang it.

Your turn

- *Say it*: **jānnā** — to know, holding the long *n*
- *Contrast*: **jānā** to go, **jānnā** to know
- *Say it*: **maiñ jāntā hūñ**, then **maiñ jāntī hūñ**
- *Run through*: all five — *honā*, *jānā*, *ānā*, *bolnā*, *jānnā* — stripping each stem
- *Connect*: **jānnā** ← *jñā-* → English **know**, **notice**, **diagnosis**

Before you move on

What single written difference separates *jānā* from *jānnā*? (A second ج, held long in speech.) Which two words in *maiñ jāntī hūñ* agree, and with what? (**Jāntī** with gender, **hūñ** with person.) And which English verb is the same word as *jānnā*? (**Know**.)

Source: Wiktionary: جَانَا.

Chapter 7

Four Verbs of the Mind

By the end of this chapter: I can say that I think, understand, read and write in Urdu, take the -nā off each verb to reach its stem, and read the two-eyed he that turns a plain consonant into an aspirated one.

The fourth verb arrives with no new letters at all: read لکھنا straight off, then run all four stems through main ...tā/tī hūn and sort the chapter's inherited verbs from the borrowed words for pen, book and script.

7.1 سوچنا — “to think,” and it used to mean “to grieve”

Say **jānnā** — the one with the doubled *n*, the one that turned out to be English **know**. Knowing is where the mind arrives. Here is the verb for the work it does on the way.

You'll want to know first — one word

سوچنا — *sochnā* — **to think**

Strip the -nā and the stem is **soch-**. That stem is also a noun: سوچ *soch*, “**a thought**” — and, just as ordinarily, “**a worry**.” Both meanings matter; the history explains them.

The letters in this word

From the right edge: س *s*, then و carrying *o*, then چ *ch*, then ن *n*, then | long *ā*.

چ is new, and you own the trick already. It is the body of چ *j* — from جی *jī* and جانا *jānā* — with **three dots below** instead of one. Second time this has happened: ب *b* has one dot below the low scoop, پ *p* has three. Counting dots stays a reading skill.

Grammar Lens: nothing new to run it

ہوں سوچتا میں — *maiñ sochtā hūñ* — **I think** (man speaking)
ہوں سوچتی میں — *maiñ sochtī hūñ* — **I think** (woman speaking)

The participle takes gender, ہوں takes person. The machine is built; every new verb walks into it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

sochnā comes through Prakrit *soccadi* from Sanskrit *śocati* — “**burns; grieves; mourns**” — on the root *śuc-*. The sense cooled by stages: *burn* → *be consumed by something* → *brood on it* → plain *think*. Urdu’s everyday word for thinking is an old word for sorrow that went quiet, which is why **soch** is still a thought *and* a worry.

State the limit plainly: *śuc-* has **no secure English cousin**. Inventing one would be worse than admitting it.

What is worth noticing sits inside Urdu. Beside inherited **soch**, Urdu keeps Arabic فکر *fikr*, “thought, reflection,” on the root *f-k-r* — and *fikr* also means **worry**: *koī fikr nahīñ*, “no worries.” Two words, two unrelated languages, opposite sides of Urdu’s vocabulary, each sliding from thinking to fretting on its own.

Your turn

- *Say it*: **sochnā** — to think; then the stem **soch-**
- *Count*: چ one dot below, چ three dots below
- *Say it*: **maiñ sochtā hūñ**, then **maiñ sochtī hūñ**
- *Run through*: **bolnā, jānnā, sochnā** — speak, know, think
- *Say it*: both meanings of the noun **soch** — a thought, and a worry

Before you move on

How many dots does چ carry, and where? (Three, below.) What did *śocati* mean before it meant “think”? (**To burn, to grieve.**) Is there an English cousin of *śuc-*? (**No.**)

Sources: Wiktionary: سوچنا; *Zero Zabar*: The Urdu alphabet.

7.2 سمجھنا — “to understand,” which is a way of waking up

You can think — *sochnā*, three dots under the چ. You can know — *jānnā*. Between brooding and knowing sits the moment a thing clicks, and Urdu has a verb for exactly that.

You’ll want to know first — one word

سمجھنا — *samajhnā* — to understand

Strip the *-nā* and the stem is **samajh-**. The stem is a noun too: سمجھ *samajh*, “understanding, sense.”

The letters in this word

From the right edge: س *s*, م *m*, ج *j*, then ه *h*, then ن *n*, then | long *ā*.

ه is *do-chashmī* he, “two-eyed he,” named for its two loops. It is not a consonant you pronounce. Its whole job is to grab the letter before it and add a puff of breath: ج *j* plus ه gives جھ *jh*.

You have used it once already. ٹھیک *thīk* is ٹ plus this same ه — retroflex *t*, then the breath. One letter, one job.

Keep it apart from ہ, *gol* he, “round he,” which is a real *h* and which you write in ہوں *hūn* and ہونا *honā*. Round ہ speaks; two-eyed ه only breathes on its right-hand neighbour.

Grammar Lens: into the frame

ہوں سمجھتا میں — *maiñ samajhtā hūñ* — **I understand** (man speaking)
ہوں سمجھتی میں — *maiñ samajhtī hūñ* — **I understand** (woman speaking)

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

samajhnā comes through Prakrit *saṃbujjhadī* from Sanskrit *sambudhyate*: **sam-**, “fully, together,” plus **budh-**, “to wake; to become aware.” To understand something is to come awake to it.

That root has a famous derivative. **Buddha** is *buddha*, “the woken one” — the same *budh-*, as are *bodhi*, the awakening, and *buddhi*, “intellect.” English borrowed all three without noticing they were relatives of anything.

One stage back the root is Indo-European **b^hewd^h-*, “be awake, be aware.” Its English descendants are quieter: **bode** and **forebode**, about being warned, and **forbid** — Old English *bēodan*, “to announce, to command,” a word for making someone aware of your will.

So Urdu’s plainest way of saying *I get it* and the Buddha’s title are one word.

Your turn

- Say it: **samajhnā** — to understand; then the stem **samajh-**
- Say it: **ṭhīk**, then **samajhnā** — hear the same **ḥ** breath in both
- Contrast: **ḥ** speaks in *hūñ*; **ḥ** only aspirates in *samajh-*
- Say it: **maiñ sochtā hūñ**, then **maiñ samajhtā hūñ** — I think, I understand
- Connect: **samajhnā** ← *budh-* → **Buddha**, “the woken one”

Before you move on

What does **ḥ** do, and does it sound by itself? (It aspirates the letter before it; **no**.) What did *budh-* mean, and which famous title is built on it? (**To wake; Buddha**.)

Sources: Wiktionary: **سمجھنا**; *Zero Zabar*: The Urdu alphabet.

7.3 پڑھنا — “to read,” and “to study,” and “to recite”

Say **samajhnā**, strip its **-nā**, and hear the breath the two-eyed **ḥ** puts into the stem. This verb uses that letter and one more.

You'll want to know first — one word

پڑھنا — *parhnā* — **to read**

It is also the ordinary word for “**to study**”: the noun پڑھائی *parhāī* is “studies, schooling.” Urdu does not keep reading and studying in separate boxes. Strip the **-nā** and the stem is **parh-**.

The letters in this word

From the right edge: پ *p*, then ژ, then ہ, then ن *n*, then | long *ā*.

Two are yours: پ, the low scoop with **three dots below**, from آپ *āp*; and ہ, the two-eyed *he* from سمجھنا — ژ plus ہ gives *rh*.

ژ is new, and built from two things you have met. Its body is ر *r*, from شکرِیہ *shukriyā*. On top sits the very mark that rides on ٹ in ٹھیک *thīk*: Urdu's retroflex sign, meaning *curl the tongue back*. ٹ is a curled *t*; ژ is a curled *r*, flicked rather than rolled.

Grammar Lens: into the frame

ہوں پڑھتا میں — *main parhtā hūn* — **I read** (man speaking)
ہوں پڑھتی میں — *main parhtī hūn* — **I read** (woman speaking)

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

parhnā comes from Prakrit *padhaī*, from Sanskrit **paṭh-**, “**to recite; to read aloud**.” Its *ṭh* softened into the flapped *rh* you have just learned, and the meaning widened from reciting to reading to studying.

Be honest about the far end: **paṭh-** has **no secure Indo-European ancestry**. There is no English cousin, and the trail stops inside India. The near end is better. The oldest sense — *speaking a text you hold in memory* — is everyday, not a fossil. To perform the Muslim ritual prayer is پڑھنا نماز *namāz parhnā*, literally “**to read** the prayer,” and nobody performing it holds a book. You already met the word for someone who does that with the whole Quran: a حافظ *hāfiz*, on the Arabic root *ḥ-f-z*, “to guard, to preserve.” Guarding a text and reciting it are two halves of one practice — one word borrowed, one inherited.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **parhnā** — to read, and to study; then the stem **parh-**

- *Count*: پ three dots below, and name the word it opens
- *Trace it*: the retroflex mark on ٹ, then the same mark on ڑ
- *Say it*: **main̄ paṛhtā hūn̄**, then **main̄ samajhtā hūn̄** — I read, I understand

Before you move on

Name the two everyday meanings of *paṛhnā*. (**To read; to study.**)
 What does the mark on ڑ tell you to do, and which other letter carries it? (**Curl the tongue back; ٹ.**) Does *paṛh-* have an English cousin? (**No.**)

Sources: Wiktionary: پڑھنا; *Zero Zabar*: The Urdu alphabet.

7.4 لکھنا — “to write,” with nothing new left to decode

Three verbs so far: *sochnā*, *samajhnā*, *paṛhnā*. Strip the ending off each and say the three stems. The fourth completes the set, and every letter in it is one you already own.

You’ll want to know first — one word

لکھنا — *likhnā* — **to write**

Strip the **-nā** and the stem is **likh-**.

The letters in this word

From the right edge: ل *l*, from سلام *salām*; ک *k*, from کیا *kyā*; then ه, the two-eyed *he*, aspirating the ک to give کہ *kh*; then ن *n* and ا long *ā*.

Not one new shape — a whole verb you can read straight off.

Grammar Lens: all four in the frame

ہوں لکھتا میں — *main̄ likhtā hūn̄* — **I write** (man speaking)
 ہوں لکھتی میں — *main̄ likhtī hūn̄* — **I write** (woman speaking)

Run the chapter through that frame without changing anything but the stem: *main̄ sochtā hūn̄*, *main̄ samajhtā hūn̄*, *main̄ paṛhtā hūn̄*, *main̄ likhtā hūn̄*. One machine, four verbs, and ہوں میں holding the ends of

every sentence.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

likhnā is Sanskrit *likhati*, “**scratches, scrapes.**” Writing was cutting a mark into a surface. Three other families reached for that picture out of three unrelated roots: Latin *scribere* “to incise,” behind **scribe** and **script**; Greek *gráphein* “to scratch,” behind **graph**; Old English *writan* “to score, to cut,” which is **write**. Four families, each deciding that writing is scratching.

Now the part only Urdu can show you. All four verbs of this chapter are inherited Indo-Aryan, the plain floor of the language — but the **things** writing needs are borrowed to a word: قلم *qalam*, the pen, Arabic from Greek *kálamos*, “a reed”; کتاب *kitāb*, the book, from the Arabic root *k-t-b*, “to write”; and نستعلیق *nasta‘līq*, the Persian name of the flowing hand Urdu is set in. The deed is inherited; the equipment came by ship.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **likhnā** — to write; then the stem **likh-**
- *Run through:* all four — *sochnā, samajhnā, paṛhnā, likhnā* — stripping each stem
- *Say it:* the four in the frame — *main sochtā hūn ... main likhtā hūn*
- *Name:* which letter is چ, which is ڄ, and what ھ does to a neighbour
- *Trace it:* *soch-* from grieving, *samajh-* from waking, *paṛh-* from reciting
- *Sort:* **likhnā** inherited; **qalam** and **kitāb** borrowed

Before you move on

Name the four verbs of this chapter and their four stems. What did *likhati* mean before it meant “write”? (**Scratches.**) Which layer of Urdu does *qalam* belong to? (**The borrowed one.**)

Sources: Wiktionary: لکھنا; Wiktionary: قلم.

Chapter 8

Four Verbs Between People

By the end of this chapter: I can take, ask and help in Urdu, build a verb by bolting a borrowed noun onto karnā, and say what I like in the sentence where the thing liked is the subject and I am only the person it happens to.

mujhe parhnā pasand hai — the first Urdu sentence the learner cannot open with main. It closes over the chapter’s own four verbs by dropping each -nā infinitive into the liked-thing slot, and reuses madad karnā’s join in pasand karnā.

8.1 لینا — “to take,” and the letter that will not sit still

Last chapter’s four verbs were about the mind. Say **likhnā**, and name which layer of Urdu *qalam* came from. Now the hands take over: four verbs about what happens between people.

You’ll want to know first — one word

لینا — *lenā* — **to take**

Strip the **-nā** and the stem is **le-**. That is the whole stem: one syllable, no consonant after the vowel. It is the shortest verb you have met, and the etymology says why.

The letters in this word

From the right edge: ل *l*, then ی *y*, then ن *n*, then ا long *ā*.

ی here carries a long **e** — *le-*, rhyming with English *lay*. That is its **third** job: it supplied a consonantal *y* in کیا *kyā* and stood for long *ī* in جی *jī*.

A fourth relative is yours too: broad final ے, which ends کیسے *kaise* and is not the shape that ends کیسی *kaisī*. One family of *ye* shapes covering *y*, *ī* and *e*, with the learned word telling you which — the abjad recording enough, not everything.

Grammar Lens: a two-letter stem in the same frame

ہوں لیتا میں — *maiṇ letā hūṇ* — **I take** (man speaking) میں
ہوں لیتی — *maiṇ letī hūṇ* — **I take** (woman speaking)

No stem is too small for the machine. **le-** plus **-tā/-tī** plus **hūṇ**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

lenā goes back to Sanskrit **labh-**, “**to gain, to obtain**.” Prakrit softened it to *lahai*, then the *-h-* went too and the vowels fused into a single *le*. A three-consonant root worn down to one syllable — the erosion that makes a language’s commonest words its shortest.

Prakrit then did something tidy: it levelled *le-* “take” against *de-* “give” so the pair matched. That is why لینا *lenā* and دینا *denā* still rhyme. They are not related; they were made to sound like partners.

On the standard comparison, *labh-* matches Greek *lambánein*, “to take, to seize” — which English borrowed repeatedly without noticing. **Syllable** is *syn-* plus *lambánein*, “letters **taken together**”; **epilepsy** is “a seizing upon”; a **lemma** is something taken as given, which is why an argument with two of them is a **dilemma**.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **lenā** — to take; then the stem, which is just **le-**
- *Name:* ی three ways — *y* in *kyā*, *ī* in *jī*, *e* in *lenā*
- *Say it:* **maiṇ letā hūṇ**, then **maiṇ letī hūṇ**
- *Say it:* **maiṇ likhtā hūṇ**, then **maiṇ letā hūṇ** — I write, I take
- *Connect:* **lenā** ← *labh-* → Greek *lambánein* → English **syllable**

Before you move on

What sound does *ṣ* carry in *lenā*, and name one other value it takes elsewhere. (**Long** *e*; *y* in *kyā* or *ī* in *jī*.) What did *labh-* mean? (**To gain, to obtain.**) Why do *lenā* and *denā* rhyme? (**Prakrit levelled the pair.**)

Sources: Wiktionary: لَبَنّا; *Zero Zabar*: The Urdu alphabet.

8.2 پوچھنا — “to ask,” a word Urdu inherited and borrowed at the same time

Say **lenā** and name the sound ۛ carries in it. You also hold ڪا *kyā*, “what,” and two whole questions built with it. Here is the verb for the act itself.

You'll want to know first — one word

پوچھنا — *pūchhnā* — to ask

Strip the **-nā** and the stem is **pūchh-**. It covers both asking a question and asking after someone.

The letters in this word

From the right edge: پ p , then و carrying long $\bar{u}$, then چ ch , then ه, then ن n , then ل long $\bar{a}$.

Every shape is already earned, and two are the dot-counting pair: ڤ has three dots **below** a low scoop, چ three below the taller *jīm* body. Then ه aspirates the چ into ڤه *chh* — its job in *samajhnā* and *parhnā* too.

A written question still ends in the mirrored **؟**, closing **آپ کا نام کیا ہے؟** at the left-hand end of the line.

Grammar Lens: into the frame

ہوں پوچھتا میں — *main pūchhṭā hūn* — **I ask** (man speaking)
ہوں پوچھتی میں — *main pūchhṭī hūn* — **I ask** (woman speaking)

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

pūchhnā is Sanskrit **pr̥cchati**, “asks,” on the Indo-European root **prek-*, “to ask.” Latin took it as *precārī*, “to beg, to pray” — hence English **pray**, **prayer**, and **precarious**, a thing held only as long as someone is willing to be asked. German still asks with it: *fragen*. English’s own inherited cousin, Old English *frīġnan*, died out, so English prays with the related word and asks with an unrelated one.

Here is the part that is Urdu’s alone. Persian asks with پرسیدن *porsīdan*, and *porsīdan* is **the same root**, carried west into Iran rather than east into India. Urdu borrowed it back: پرسش *pursish* is “inquiry, asking after someone’s health,” and پرسان حال *pursān-e-ḥāl* is “one who asks how you are.”

So *pūchhnā* came down the inherited road, *pursish* came in sideways off a Persian ship, and they are cousins. Urdu is the room where the two roads meet, and the wellbeing question آپ کیسے ہیں؟ *āp kaise hain* is what either of them names.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **pūchhnā** — to ask; then the stem **pūchh-**
- *Count:* three dots below پ, three below چ, then ه for the breath
- *Say it:* **maiñ pūchhtā hūñ**, then **maiñ pūchhtī hūñ**
- *Say it:* **kyā**, then **āp kaise haiñ** — a word and a question about asking
- *Connect:* **pūchhnā** and Persian **pursish** ← one root → English **pray**

Before you move on

Which English word for praying shares a root with *pūchhnā*, and are Persian *porsīdan* and Urdu *pūchhnā* related? (**Pray; the same root, by two roads.**)

Sources: Wiktionary: پوچھنا; Wiktionary: پرسیدن; Rekhta Dictionary: pursish.

8.3 کرنا مدد — “to help,” and the join that built half of Urdu

Say **pūchhnā** and name the English word for praying that shares its root. Every verb so far was one word ending in **-nā**. This one is two, and only the second half moves.

You’ll want to know first — two words

کرنا مدد — *madad karnā* — to help

مدد *madad* is a **noun**: “**help, aid**.” Alone it does nothing. کرنا *karnā* is the verb “to do,” already readable: ك from *kyā*, ر from *shukriyā*, then -نا. Bolt them together: “**to do help**.”

Grammar Lens: only the second half conjugates

ہوں کرتا مدد میں — *main madad kartā hūn* — **I help** (man speaking)
ہوں کرتی مدد میں — *main madad kartī hūn* — **I help** (woman speaking)

Madad never changes. It is not a verb and never becomes one; *karnā* carries every ending. This is the **conjunct verb**, the most productive verb-making device Urdu owns: name a noun, add *karnā*, and you have a verb.

You have met *karnā*’s stem before without being told. خوشی کر مل سے آپ — *āp se mil kar khushī huī* — holds کر *kar* in the middle doing a different job: “**having** met.” One little word, two pieces of machinery.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

مدد is Arabic, on the three-consonant root د-د-م (*m-d-d*), whose verb *madda* means “**to stretch out, to extend**.” Help, in Arabic, is something **extended** toward you — the picture English reaches for when it *extends* a hand, though English inherited nothing from *m-d-d* and its own **help** is unrelated Germanic. Better said plainly than dressed up as a cousin.

The root pattern is not new. حافظ *hāfiz* sits on ظ-ف-ح, “to guard, to preserve.” Three consonants carrying a meaning, vowels poured in around them: that is how Arabic builds words, and now you have two. *Madad* travelled the same road as خدا *khudā* — into Persian first, then

into Urdu.

Here is why the join matters more than the word. A borrowed noun **cannot be conjugated**. With *karnā* it never has to: the loan stays a frozen noun and native grammar does the work. That is how Urdu took in centuries of Persian and Arabic vocabulary without changing its verb system by one letter.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- **madad karnā** — to help; and which half is the noun
- **maiñ madad kartā hūñ**, then **maiñ madad kartī hūñ**
- two Arabic roots — *ḥ-f-ẓ* to guard, *m-d-d* to extend
- **maiñ pūchhtā hūñ**, then **maiñ madad kartā hūñ** — I ask, I help

Before you move on

Which half of *madad karnā* takes the endings, and what does *m-d-d* mean underneath? (کرتا; **to stretch out, to extend**.) Why does this join let Urdu borrow so freely? (**The loan stays a noun; native *karnā* carries the grammar.**)

Sources: Wiktionary: مدد; Wiktionary: مد (Arabic).

8.4 پسند — Urdu does not like things; things please Urdu

Say **maiñ madad kartā hūñ** and name which half takes the endings. Every sentence so far opened with میں *maiñ*, “I.” This one takes that away.

You’ll want to know first — مجھے, the shape of “to me”

مجھے — *mujhe* — to me

Mujhe is what میں *maiñ* becomes when the sentence refuses to let you be its subject. It is not “I.”

The letters in this word

From the right edge: م *m*, ج *j*, ه aspirating it to *jh*, then broad final ے for *e* — the shape that ends کیسے *kaise*. All four already yours.

Grammar Lens: the thing you like is the subject

پسند پڑھنا مجھے — *mujhe paṛhnā pasand hai*. — **I like reading.**

Taken apart: **mujhe** + **paṛhnā** (“reading”) + **pasand** (“pleasing”) + **hai**. Literally: “**To me, reading is pleasing.**”

پڑھنا is the **subject**, which is what ے agrees with. No Urdu sentence puts *I* in front of *like*. And any **-nā** infinitive drops into that slot, because an Urdu infinitive doubles as a noun — so every verb of the last three chapters is likeable.

پسند لکھنا مجھے — *mujhe likhnā pasand hai*. — **I like writing.**

Urdu keeps company with unrelated languages: Spanish *me gusta el libro*, “to me the book pleases”; Italian *mi piace*; Tamil *enakku piḍikkum*, “it catches me”; Bengali *āmār bhālo lāge*, “good sticks to me.” Three families borrowing nothing from each other, each deciding liking happens to you.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

پسند is not a verb. It is **Persian**, from پسندیدن *pasandīdan*, “to approve, to find pleasing” — *pati-*, “towards,” plus *sand*, “to look good.” It arrived as a noun and adjective, and a non-verb cannot carry the liker, so the grammar put that person elsewhere: **mujhe**.

Where *sand* goes next is genuinely **disputed**. One proposal ties it to the root behind Latin *candere*, “to glow” — English **candid**, **incendiary** — and Sanskrit *candra*, “moon,” Urdu’s چاند *chānd*. Lovely, but unsettled. It came by the Persian road that gave you خوشی *khushī*, and sits beside Arabic مدد *madad*. *Lenā* and *pūchhnā* are inherited; *madad* and *pasand* are borrowed. Urdu’s hands stayed home; its social words travelled.

پسند کرنا *pasand karnā*, “to do liking,” reuses *madad karnā*’s join; پسند آنا *pasand ānā* uses آنا *ānā*, “to come” — liking that *comes*.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **mujhe paṛhnā pasand hai**, then its literal sense
- *Swap:* hold **mujhe ... pasand hai**, change the middle — *likhnā* · *sochnā* · *pūchhnā*
- *Say it:* the chapter — *main letā hūn*, *main pūchhtā hūn*, *main madad kartā hūn*, *mujhe paṛhnā pasand hai*
- *Sort:* *lenā*, *pūchhnā* inherited; *madad*, *pasand* borrowed

Before you move on

In *mujhe paṛhnā pasand hai*, what is the subject, and what part of speech is *pasand*? (پڑھنا; a **noun and adjective** from **Persian**.)

Sources: Wiktionary: پسند; Wiktionary: پسندیدن.

A note on sources

Script descriptions follow Northwestern University’s open Zero Zabar Urdu-alphabet materials. Chapter 4’s wellbeing forms and register contrast, together with Chapter 5’s farewell, follow Michigan State University’s open *Basic Urdu*.